

roundupnewsbot — v3.0 report

Report date: 19 July 2026 · **Status:** Fully operational — best health in the project’s history · **Follows on from:** v2.0 report, 16 February 2026

Executive summary

Since the February report, the bot has been through its biggest overhaul yet. Three headlines:

- 1 Coverage is now 100%.** Every one of the 534 enabled Australian councils is being scraped successfully — up from 95% in February. The last holdouts (remote Cape York councils that publish newsletters as PDFs) are now on the feeds too.
- 2 It moved off the cloud and into the home office.** The bot now runs on Rakali, a small home server, instead of a rented cloud server. The paid proxy service is gone too. Running costs went from ~\$31.50/month to effectively zero.
- 3 It’s dramatically more trustworthy.** A deep engineering review in early July found and fixed ~50 defects — including several that had been silently losing articles or silently disabling councils for months. The system’s whole philosophy changed from “looks fine” to “fails loudly”: if something breaks now, we know within hours, automatically.

There’s also a public face now: **lgnews.jonathonmarsden.com** — one page showing all eight state feeds live, no login, no tracking, no paywall.

What changed since v2.0 — the short version

	February (v2.0)	July (v3.0)
Councils scraping successfully	512 of 537 (95%)	534 of 535 enabled (100%) ¹
Where it runs	Rented cloud server (\$20/mo)	Rakali home server (\$0)
Proxy service	Webshare (\$10/mo)	Cancelled — proven unnecessary
Total running cost	~\$31.50/month	≈ \$0/month
Articles in the database	~13,800	35,796
Monitoring	Hourly Discord messages	Quiet-by-default alerts + daily digest + an independent off-site watchdog
Deploying new code	Push → cloud scripts → server	Merging approved code <i>is</i> deploying (the server updates itself within 10 minutes)
Duplicate-post protection	Best effort	Guaranteed exactly-once posting
Public face	None	lgnews.jonathonmarsden.com

¹ One council (Pormpuraaw, QLD) is deliberately switched off with documented evidence: it genuinely publishes no news anywhere on its website. It gets re-checked quarterly.

A note on posting volume, in the interest of honesty: the February report quoted ~900 posts/day. Today the steady rate is 100–250 genuinely new stories per weekday. The old figure was inflated — the review found bugs that re-posted old articles, counted rejected posts as published, and let one council flood the queue. Today every story posts exactly once, and quiet weekends are quiet. Fewer, better posts.

The July engineering review

In early July the entire codebase went under the microscope: roughly 50 verified defects, from cosmetic to critical. The important families:

- **Silent article loss.** A temporary Bluesky outage used to permanently discard every article that tried to post during it. Fixed — articles now wait and retry, with a sensible cap.
- **Silent council loss.** The “circuit breaker” that switches off broken scrapers was a one-way door: once off, a council could never come back without manual surgery, and network failures were miscounted in a way that quietly disabled 85+ councils at once (twice!). Now failures are counted honestly, disabled councils automatically retry every few days, and mass-disable events raise the alarm immediately.
- **Garbled text.** The occasional “€”-style characters in posts were traced to their root cause — a text-encoding bug at download time — and fixed at the source rather than patched after the fact.
- **Wrong dates.** Eight separate places parsed Australian dates the American way round. All routed through one correct parser.
- **The watchmen now have watchmen.** The monitoring scripts themselves used to be able to die silently. They now report their own failures, and a second, independent watchdog runs every six hours from GitHub’s computers — so even if the entire home server loses power, something external notices and raises the alarm.

The move home — and why it made the bot better

The migration to the home server was planned as a cost-saving exercise. It turned out to be a coverage breakthrough.

While testing, we discovered that many council websites’ security systems (especially South Australia’s shared platform) **block traffic from data-centre internet addresses outright** — the cloud server’s address class, and the paid proxy’s too. The proxy we’d been paying for was being blocked by the exact websites it was meant to help with. From a normal home internet connection, those same websites answer happily.

So the move recovered **50–90 councils the cloud server could never reach**, made the proxy genuinely useless (cancelled), and cut costs to zero. The migration itself ran in a single evening — database copied and verified to the last row, posting confirmed exactly-once, and the old server kept as a safety net for 48 hours before being destroyed.

Home hosting done properly, for the sceptics: the bot lives in an isolated container with nightly full-machine backups, daily database backups, no inbound internet exposure at all, and that off-site watchdog keeping honest score from outside the house.

Finishing the map: the last 25 councils

- **22 broken scrapers repaired in one day** — mostly councils that had rebuilt their websites (a wave of Victorian councils re-platformed almost simultaneously). Every fix was verified against the live site before shipping.
- **The three “PDF-only” Cape York and outback councils** are now on the feeds. The trick: don’t read the PDFs — post the newsletter’s title with a link to the PDF, dated from its name (“Waanta Newsletter October 2025”). And one of the three turned out to have quietly launched a proper news page two years ago; nobody had looked.
- Remote communities like Wujal Wujal and Lockhart River now appear on Bluesky alongside the capital cities — arguably the most meaningful coverage in the whole project.

The February roadmap — scorecard

v2.0 said	What happened
Improve silent-failure detection	Done, and then some (the failure/empty distinction, automatic retry probation, dual watchdogs)
Performance dashboard	Delivered as a public website instead — lgnews.jonathonmarsden.com
More RSS support	Partly — several councils moved to cleaner API-based scraping instead
New Zealand expansion	Not yet — still attractive, easier now (no proxy cost scaling)
ML content filtering	Not yet — volume bugs fixed first; filtering matters less now
Multi-platform posting	Not yet — Bluesky remains bot-friendly

What’s next

1. **A brand refresh for the eight Bluesky accounts** — consistent names, proper bios, banners matching the website — prepared and being finalised with LG News Roundup, followed by a starter pack and a proper launch push. The feeds have ~126 followers today; the growth plan targets 1,000+ in 90 days.
2. **Growing the readership**: council comms teams, LG professionals, journalists, and the peak bodies — with the VLGA connection through LG News Roundup as the first door to knock on.
3. **Possible products on top**: keyword watchlists and per-council custom feeds for organisations that need them — the free public network is the demonstration.
4. New Zealand, when the time is right.

How the work gets done now

Worth saying plainly: much of the July overhaul — the review, the fixes, the migration, the repairs — was executed by AI engineering assistants (Anthropic’s Claude), working under direction and review, with every change tested and human-approved before going live. That’s not a gimmick; it’s why a one-person public-interest project can now run at a standard — full audits, verified migrations, 100% coverage — that used to

take a team. The same approach is available for other projects: if your organisation needs this kind of site, data service, or automation, talk to me.

The same questions, updated answers

Is this sustainable? More than ever. Costs are ~zero, the code is documented to a standard a stranger could pick up, the system fixes and reports itself for everything routine, and the single-maintainer risk is softened by automation and thorough hand-over documentation.

Is it legal? Unchanged: public information, titles and links only, full attribution, traffic driven *to* councils. No complaints to date — councils get free reach out of it.

What does it cost? Electricity and a domain name. The February figure of \$378/year is now roughly \$18.

Who's it for? Everyone — that's the point. No paywall, no tracking, no editorial line. Raw council news as it happens, offered as a public good.

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Live feeds: lgnews.jonathonmarsden.com · **Code:** github.com/jonathonmarsden/council-news-bot · **Next review:** October 2026